bastions.

Cries of ‘Allah-u-Akbar’ echoed across the hilltops, writes Abul Fazl; and they carried their message far across the desert land. First Chittorgarh, now Ranthambore had fallen. The great Rajput clans crumbled in their wake, one by one. Five hundred kilometres east of Ranthambore, Raja Ram Chand of Panna had only to hear of Surjan’s surrender to send Akbar the keys of his own fort, the mighty Kalinjar. The last man who tried to breach Kalinjar’s thick walls had perished in the attempt – Sher Shah Suri was shot through with shrapnel and suffocated from his own mine, trying to blast his way in. Akbar didn’t so much as step in its direction.

Kalinjar’s keys arrived in August 1569; by the winter of the next year, Akbar had also received princesses from Bikaner and Jaisalmer, as well as homage from Marwar. Chandrasen, whose father, Maldeo, had once hunted Humayun across a burning desert, had submitted to Humayun’s son.[57]

To gain the fealty, one after the other, of these Rajput chiefs was Akbar’s first truly great achievement. Without it – without the men who now filled his court and expanded his armies – Akbar’s empire might never have stretched as far nor settled as deep as it did. It wasn’t just the military might they gave him, nor the political legitimacy. Rajasthan was also economically vital to the health of any Hindustani empire, allowing, as it did, trade between the bustling ports of Gujarat and the north Indian plains.[58]

Abul Fazl makes a none-too-subtle allusion to this at the very beginning of the *Akbarnama*, when expanding on one of the several horoscopes made for the padishah. Not Maulana Chand’s jottings, which made Humayun dance in the privy, but a horoscope cast by a Persian scholar called Amir Fathullah Shirazi, three decades into Akbar’s reign. Naturally, then, Amir Fathullah’s predictions carry more than a hint of hindsight, as, for example, in his calculations that show how Humayun will ‘depart to the eternal city’ when his son reaches ‘the years of discretion’. It is Fathullah’s horoscope, too, that has Akbar marrying women from ‘the ruling families of India’.[59]

That is to say: whether any holders of ‘orthodox Muslim sentiments’ liked it or not, Akbar was joined to the Rajputs by the stars. And now, by blood: in the very month that Kalinjar’s keys arrived in his court, Akbar also received the joyful news of the birth of his first son, born to his first Rajput